ENGLISH I · WEEK 3

English I week 3 rules: Articles, prepositions and phrasal verbs

Articles: a, an, the · Prepositions & conjunctions · Phrasal verbs, idioms & collocations. Save this PDF for revision.

ARTICLES: A, AN, THE · IN EVERY PAPER

Articles: a, an, the

a

before a consonant sound

a laptop, a cold day, a book, a university, a European, a one-way street

an

before a vowel sound

an emergency exit, an hour, an honest man, an MBA, an umbrella

the: specific

something already known or identified

'Pass me the book on the table.'

the: unique

only one exists

the Sun, the Earth, the sky, the east

ARTICLES: A, AN, THE · IN EVERY PAPER

Articles: a, an, the

the: rank

superlatives and ordinals

the best, the first, the only

the: geography

rivers, seas, oceans, mountain ranges, island groups

the Ganga, the Himalayas, holidays in the mountains

No article

single mountains, most countries and cities, languages, meals, sports, general abstract ideas

Mount Everest, India, English, breakfast, cricket

PREPOSITIONS & CONJUNCTIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Prepositions of time and place

Use	When	Examples
at	an exact time or point	at 5 pm, at night, at the station
on	days, dates, surfaces	on Monday, on 5 May, on the table
in	months, years, seasons, parts of the day, inside	in May, in 2024, in the morning, in the fridge (PYQ)
since / for	starting point / length of time	since Monday / for two hours
ahead of	before someone in a line	standing in line ahead of me (PYQ)

PREPOSITIONS & CONJUNCTIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Fixed phrases

Phrase	Example
worried about	Sushma is worried about the exam. (PYQ)
in my opinion	In my opinion, she is clever. (PYQ)
look into	Look into the matter (investigate). (PYQ)
interested in · good at · afraid of	She is good at maths but afraid of heights.
depend on · responsible for · different from	Who is responsible for this?
angry with a person · about a thing	She was angry with him about the delay.

PREPOSITIONS & CONJUNCTIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Conjunctions

Kind	Words	Example
Coordinating (FANBOYS)	for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	He may be poor but his character is faultless. (PYQ)
Correlative (pairs)	both…and, either…or, neither…nor, not only…but also	The culprit was both fined and punished. (PYQ)
Subordinating	because, although, if, unless, while, until, as if, so that	She behaves as if she was the captain. (PYQ)

PREPOSITIONS & CONJUNCTIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Common traps

⚠ 'As if' introduces an imagined comparison; plain 'as' means 'in the way that' or 'because'.

⚠ 'Beyond' in 'beyond Zuckerberg's post' is a preposition (PYQ May 2024).

PHRASAL VERBS, IDIOMS & COLLOCATIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Separable vs inseparable

Test

put 'it' in the middle: 'sum it up' ✓ → separable · 'take it after' ✗ → inseparable

Separable

sum up (PYQ), call by (PYQ), bring up, turn off, put off, pick up, give up, call off, fill in

Inseparable

come across (PYQ), look after, live on, see about, take after, hit on, keep at, stand for, look into, wait on, get over, run into

PHRASAL VERBS, IDIOMS & COLLOCATIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Phrasal verb meanings

Phrasal verb	Meaning
wait on	serve someone (PYQ)
lay off (something)	stop doing or using it (PYQ: TRUE); also: dismiss workers
break up	end: 'The meeting broke up before dinner' (PYQ)
break out	start suddenly (war, fire)
break into	enter by force
bring up	raise a child: 'The kids were well brought up' (PYQ)

PHRASAL VERBS, IDIOMS & COLLOCATIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Phrasal verb meanings

Phrasal verb	Meaning
bring out	publish or launch
come across	find by chance (PYQ: inseparable)
look into	investigate
take after	resemble a parent
put off · call off · get off	postpone · cancel · leave a bus or train
put up with	tolerate

PHRASAL VERBS, IDIOMS & COLLOCATIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Idioms

Idiom	Meaning
a dark horse	an unexpected winner (PYQ)
cut corners	do something the fastest, cheapest way (PYQ: TRUE)
break the ice	remove the tension at a first meeting (PYQ)
get out of hand	become difficult to control (PYQ)
cost an arm and a leg	be very expensive (PYQ)
keep someone in the loop	keep them updated (PYQ)
be on board	agree with, support (PYQ)
take a hit	be affected badly (PYQ)
once in a blue moon	very rarely

PHRASAL VERBS, IDIOMS & COLLOCATIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Idioms

Idiom	Meaning
under the weather	slightly ill
spill the beans	reveal a secret
hit the nail on the head	be exactly right
a blessing in disguise	a good thing that first seemed bad
burn the midnight oil	work late into the night
see eye to eye	agree
beat around the bush	avoid the main point
call it a day	stop working
a piece of cake	very easy

PHRASAL VERBS, IDIOMS & COLLOCATIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Collocations: every paper has a 5-item match

Paper	Pairs
May 2023	land acquisition · moral decay · final blow · weather forecast · unanimous decision
Sep 2023	sports equipment · library card · garden hose · job offer · fishing rod
May 2024	bank account · strong coffee · lazy afternoon · short temper · ancient ruins
Also learn	heavy rain · make a decision · do homework · take a break · pay attention · catch a cold · commit a crime · deep sleep · golden opportunity · tight schedule · broad daylight

PHRASAL VERBS, IDIOMS & COLLOCATIONS · IN EVERY PAPER

Common traps

⚠ Tip: Match collocations in two passes: lock the pairs you're sure of first (weather forecast, bank account), then the leftovers fall into place.

Notes for every week of English I, free.

Full notes, the rule sheet and common traps, with worked PYQs.

btechi.in/qualifier/notes/english-1 →

Save this PDF for revision. Share it with a friend writing the Qualifier.

Not affiliated with IIT Madras.